

THE CLAUDE BEAST | EPISODE 08 | February 2026

EXA MCP

AI-Native Web Search for Claude Code

How Exa transforms Claude from a static AI into a dynamic research assistant with real-time access to the entire web.

What Is Exa?

AI-Native Search Engine

- Built from the ground up for LLMs, not retrofitted
- Semantic search vs. keyword matching
- Returns clean, structured content optimized for AI
- Handles complex natural language queries
- Specialized verticals: company, people, **code**, academic

MCP: The "USB-C for AI"

THE PROBLEM

LLMs cannot interact with the real world on their own. Connecting 5 AI apps to 10 services previously required 50 custom integrations.

THE SOLUTION

Model Context Protocol (MCP) -- an open standard by Anthropic.
Build one connection, any MCP client can use it.



Open Standard

JSON-RPC 2.0
Not locked to any vendor



Dynamic Discovery

AI discovers tools
at runtime



15+ AI Tools

Claude, Cursor, VS Code
Gemini CLI, Codex...



30% Savings

Reduced integration
development cost

Setup in 30 Seconds

ZERO FRICTION: No API key, no npm install, no local dependencies



Terminal

```
$ claude mcp add --transport http exa https://mcp.exa.ai/mcp
```

THREE SETUP OPTIONS

1. Free Remote Server

No API key needed. Generous free tier with rate limits.
<https://mcp.exa.ai/mcp>

2. With API Key

\$10 free credits on signup. Higher rate limits.
Append `?exaApiKey=YOUR_KEY` to the URL

3. Local npm Package

Full control. Additional tools (Twitter, academic papers).
`npx -y exa-mcp-server`

8 Tools at Your Fingertips



DEFAULT

`web_search_exa`

General web search



DEFAULT

`get_code_context_exa`

Code & docs search



DEFAULT

`company_research_exa`

Company intelligence



`crawling_exa`

URL content extraction



`deep_researcher_start`

AI research agent



`people_search_exa`

Professional profiles



`web_search_advanced`

Advanced filters



`deep_researcher_check`

Get research results

Developer Use Cases

Documentation Lookup

Fetch latest API docs for any framework.
No more stale training data references.

"Find the latest Next.js 15 server actions docs"

Code Examples

Pull real snippets from GitHub & Stack Overflow.
Ground suggestions in verified, working code.

"Find FastAPI OAuth2 dependency injection examples"

Deep Research

Autonomous multi-hop research with cited sources.
Structured JSON output for programmatic use.

"Research the AI code assistant competitive landscape"

Real-Time Web Access

Access information published after training cutoff.
Current news, announcements, and updates.

"What were the key React conference announcements?"

Company Intelligence

Research competitors, partners, or targets.
Funding, headcount, tech stack, web traffic.

"Research Anthropic's latest funding and products"

Content Extraction

Read full articles from any known URL.
Clean text extraction for analysis.

"Get the full text of this blog post: [URL]"

Why Training Data Alone Is Not Enough



Core Insight

Claude's training data is a snapshot frozen in time. Exa MCP transforms Claude from a static knowledge system into a dynamic research assistant.

LIMITATION	HOW EXA SOLVES IT
Knowledge Cutoff	Real-time access to current web content
Stale Documentation	Fetches latest docs, changelogs, API references
Hallucinated Code	Grounds suggestions in real GitHub/SO examples
No Live Data	Current news, events, announcements on demand
Missing Context	Pull specific articles and research papers
Shallow Research	Deep Researcher: multi-step, multi-source, autonomous

Critical for: fast-moving fields (AI, web dev) | time-sensitive decisions | technical accuracy | reducing hallucination

Get Started Now

1. STEP 1: Add Exa MCP

```
claude mcp add exa -e EXA_API_KEY=$KEY -- npx -y exa-mcp-server
```

2. STEP 2: Restart Claude Code

Exit and reopen Claude Code to load the new MCP server

3. STEP 3: Verify Tools

Ask Claude: "What Exa tools do you have available?"

4. STEP 4: Test It

Ask Claude: "Search for the latest TypeScript 5.7 features"

5. STEP 5: Enable All Tools

```
claude mcp add --transport http exa  
"https://mcp.exa.ai/mcp?tools=web_search_exa,get_code_context_exa,  
crawling_exa,company_research_exa,deep_researcher_start,deep_researcher_check"
```